generators regularly—an outstanding amount of over Rs 80,000 crore had accumulated on this account (this crossed Rs 1.4 lakh crore by the end of financial year 2020–21). Smart metering addresses a small part of the gap. But even for that, there was no additional provision in the Budget.

Agriculture Expenditure Continued the Old Package of Interventions

The Government of India runs dozens of agriculture and food security-related programmes with an approximate budgeted outlay of Rs 3,50,000 crore. In addition, food subsidy expenditure of Rs 68,200 crore and irrigation works of Rs 5000 crore were proposed to be funded through NSSF. Total expenditure on agriculture-related programmes in Budget 2020–21 came to about Rs 4.23 lakh crore, about 24 per cent of the total discretionary expenditure of the government.

A large part of this expenditure, including Rs 75,000 crore of PM-Kisan and Rs 1,83,770 crore of food subsidy totalling Rs 3.29 lakh crore, essentially relates to redistribution. The remaining Rs 94,000 crore (including fertilizer subsidy) can be considered to be intended to stimulate agricultural growth. This expenditure is incurred through numerous (exceeding fifty) production and productivity-enhancing programmes, which are largely input-driven (seeds, fertilizer, loan, insurance, pesticides). There was no change in this large number of thinly funded agriculture development programmes for the year 2020–21.

Almost all these supposedly growth-stimulating programmes in the agriculture sector were designed in the 1970s and 1980s (they have been repackaged with different names over the past fifty years) to popularize the use of agriculture inputs and training and visit the technologies of the green revolution era. The job of popularizing these inputs was over a long time ago. In fact, there is now a problem of overuse of many inputs, like